

Genre: (Arcade) Racing
 Studio: Blackrock Studio
 Publishers: Disney Interactive
 Distributors: Excel Interactive
 * Platforms: PlayStation 3, PC (MS
 Windows), Xbox 360
 Price: Rs. 999/-

RACING AND WRECKING

In Split/Second, the player takes on the role of a race car driver in a reality show on TV

SPLIT/SECOND

In keeping with the game's setting, the levels in the single-player campaign are divided into episodes and each episode has multiple races. The game rewards the player with credits and the amount is dependent on the player's finishing position. A central element of the game design is a move called Power Play, that lets you control the outcome of the race by wrecking opponent's cars, opening up shortcuts or drastically changing the race track. Performing stunts like jumps, scarcely avoiding obstacles, drafting behind opponents or by drifting through turns are ways in which the meter can be filled. A partially filled meter lets the player execute level one Power Play moves like blowing up parked cars and

building structures or opening up short-cuts. A completely filled Power Play meter allows execution of level two moves that change the course of the race track and also has the potential to take out multiple opponents in one fell swoop. Timing these moves correctly is absolutely essential, since mistiming a trigger may actually take your own car out instead of the opponents.

Money, cars and glory

At the end of each race, the game rewards the player with credits. Earning a certain amount of credit unlocks events and new vehicles. The prime objective of each episode is to unlock and win the last race that features elite racers.

There is a fairly decent amount of variety in terms of cars, tracks and event types. There are mainly three classes of cars — sports, GT and SUV. Tracks are designed around a certain theme like an intercity free way, airplane scrap-yard, nuclear power plant and a few more. Event types include the tradition time trials, circuit races and elimination.

Along with credits and new rides, the game features another little reward that gives the player bragging rights. Achieving a certain milestone—like wrecking a set number of opponents or winning by a fraction of a second—earns the player with decals that are automatically applied to all the vehicles that the player has unlocked. There is a great deal of decals that can be unlocked and while some are quite easy to earn, others require serious skills. While the decals serve solely aesthetic purpose in

Single Player mode, it is also a way of flaunting skills during multiplayer races.

After the glory

There is quite a bit a player can do after winning the Split/Second season. There are new rides and decals that can be unlocked. The player can also attempt any of the events again to earn gold ranking in all of them. Aside from single-player modes, the game also features multiplayer over internet, LAN or offline split-screen. I personally did not have good luck with online multiplayer—each time staring at an empty game lobby.

Split/Second is worthy of a try if you like games like Fatal Racing or even Rock 'n' Roll racing. There are couple of areas where the developers could have done better. For instance, while the game is supposed to be a TV show, actual game-play does not give that impression. Something like commentary would have certainly helped to achieve that effect. Also, it would have helped if there was some form of a speed meter in the game, because without one it is hard to judge the loss of speed and subsequently device if it's better to break at a turn or drift through it. Split/Second is a fun and fairly robust game in its own rights; however serious racers might want to steer clear of this one. **d**